

KIQ 2.2 — Methodological Note on the Proxy Approach

METRO AG SCI Project — Patent & SCOPUS Strategy for Competitor Evolution Analysis

KIQ 2.2

"How are competitors — including incumbents and digital-native entrants — evolving their digital ordering capabilities?"

1. The honest gap

A patent corpus on B2B digital ordering technologies **cannot directly** tell us how Sysco, Bidcorp, Choco, or Rekki are evolving their digital capabilities. These companies do not file patents. Direct competitor-name filtering on Espacenet returns essentially zero patents (Amazon Technologies dominates with 861 of 890 results, but Amazon is a tech filer, not a HoReCa-specific actor; "Sysco S.p.A." matches an Italian IT integrator unrelated to the foodservice giant). Patents — even via proxy — will never answer KIQ 2.2 *directly*.

2. What the patent proxy CAN tell you

The proxy's actual job is to map the **technology environment** surrounding competitor evolution: who is building the B2B ordering technologies competitors will deploy, where IP is concentrated, what new technology creators are emerging. This is *indirect* evidence about competitor evolution — the supply side of the technology market in which competitors operate.

The proxy logic mirrors KIQ 2.1, pointed at a different question:

- **KIQ 2.1:** "What trends will shape HoReCa ordering?" → patents on accelerating tech
- **KIQ 2.2 patent dimension:** "What technology environment surrounds competitor evolution?" → patents on B2B ordering tech competitors will adopt

3. Why HoReCa is correctly absent from the query

KIQ 2.1 already established (Finding #5) that **no top filer is HoReCa-specific** — the technologies are sector-neutral. Adding "HoReCa" to the KIQ 2.2 query would falsely narrow the corpus and miss the real signal. The HoReCa-specificity question is answered upstream and does not need to be re-asked here.

4. Where the competitor-evolution evidence actually lives

SCOPUS. The fourth indicator listed for KIQ 2.2 is explicit: *"Scientific publications on B2B e-commerce platform evolution and partnerships."* Academic literature documents these companies even when they do not file patents — case studies of Sysco's digital transformation, Choco's market entry, foodservice platform evolution, partnership announcements, etc. **SCOPUS is the primary evidence base for KIQ 2.2; the patent corpus is the supporting context.**

5. Methodological note for the report

*KIQ 2.2 is approached via two complementary proxies. The Espacenet corpus on B2B digital ordering technologies maps the **upstream IP environment** in which competitors operate — who creates technology, where IP is concentrated, which new entrants are surfacing in the*

*technology-creator space. SCOPUS literature on B2B e-commerce platform evolution provides the **direct evidence** on how named competitors are documented as evolving their digital ordering capabilities. The two corpora answer different aspects of the KIQ: patents show the technology context, SCOPUS shows competitor-specific evolution. Critically, the absence of patents filed by the foodservice competitors themselves — confirmed by the failed competitor-name query — is itself a finding that reinforces KIQ 2.1's thesis: the industry deploys technology, it does not invent it.*

Bottom line

The patent analysis for KIQ 2.2 is doing real work — but for a **different angle** of the KIQ than first appears. It maps the technology environment, not the competitor adoption pattern. SCOPUS carries the competitor-specific evolution story. The two together — plus the negative finding from the competitor-name query — produce a defensible, triangulated answer.